ALPACA

Vicugna pacos

1. What can it see, hear, or feel?
Tall ears turn toward sounds, wide eyes spot movement on open slopes, and its nose knows the herd.

2. Where does it live — and why?
It lives on cold mountain grasslands very high up, where the herd shares warmth and safety.

3. How does it send messages?
It hums quietly to its herd, gives a sharp alarm call, and can spit if crowded too close.

4. What does it do when something changes?
When alarmed, the whole herd groups tightly together and watches before deciding to move.

5. How does it learn?
A baby alpaca stays close to its mother, copies her grazing, and learns alarm signals from adults.

6. How does it have babies?
A mother has one baby after about eleven months, and it stands within an hour of birth.

7. What are its limits?
Sudden cold or storms high in the mountains can drive the herd down to lower ground fast.

8. What does this teach us?
Its thick coat traps warm air — a quiet example of environment shaping design.

WHY IS THIS ANIMAL HERE?

Alpacas are a domesticated species, shaped by people over thousands of years.

They come from the high Andes of Peru, Bolivia, and Chile.

Today they live almost entirely on farms and ranches, not in the wild.

When its habitat shrinks:

- their wild ancestor, the vicuña, was nearly hunted to extinction
- mountain ecosystems in the Andes are changing with climate and grazing
- careful, small-scale farming still supports Andean communities

This place is not their natural home, but it can help keep the species alive.

THINK ABOUT THIS

If your ears could turn to catch every tiny sound, how would you know which noises to trust?

What a living thing can sense becomes its reality.
Environment shapes design.

SCAN TO LEARN MORE